

The Rockies



THE ROCKIES ARE A VAST range of mountains that stretch down the western side of North America. The Rockies form a barrier to the moist winds that sweep toward the continent from the Pacific Ocean. As these winds rise up over the mountains and cool, the water they carry falls as rain or snow. On the mountain peaks, winds can reach 200 mph (320 kph) and temperatures may fall to -60°F (-51°C). The Rockies provide a refuge for animals that have been hunted or driven out of other habitats by people. Some species are specially adapted for climbing and jumping on the mountain slopes. Many animals have warm fur to protect them against the cold and the winds.

Grizzled giant

The huge grizzly bear gets its name from the whitish (grizzled) tips of its hair. It can kill an animal as large as a moose or caribou, but usually feeds on smaller animals, fish, and plants. A grizzly can run as fast as a horse for short distances and may stand up on its back legs to get a better view of its prey, which it kills with its long front claws. In fall, the grizzly eats as much as possible to build up stores of fat to last it through its winter hibernation.

Grizzly bear (*Ursus arctos horribilis*)
Total length: up to 9 ft 10 in (3 m)



Rocky Mountain parnassian (*Parnassius sminthius*)
Wingspan: up to 2.6 in (6.8 cm)

Summer butterfly

Male phoebus butterflies appear in the Rockies in mid-summer. They fly across the meadows to find the females, which emerge eight to ten days later.

Spiky armor

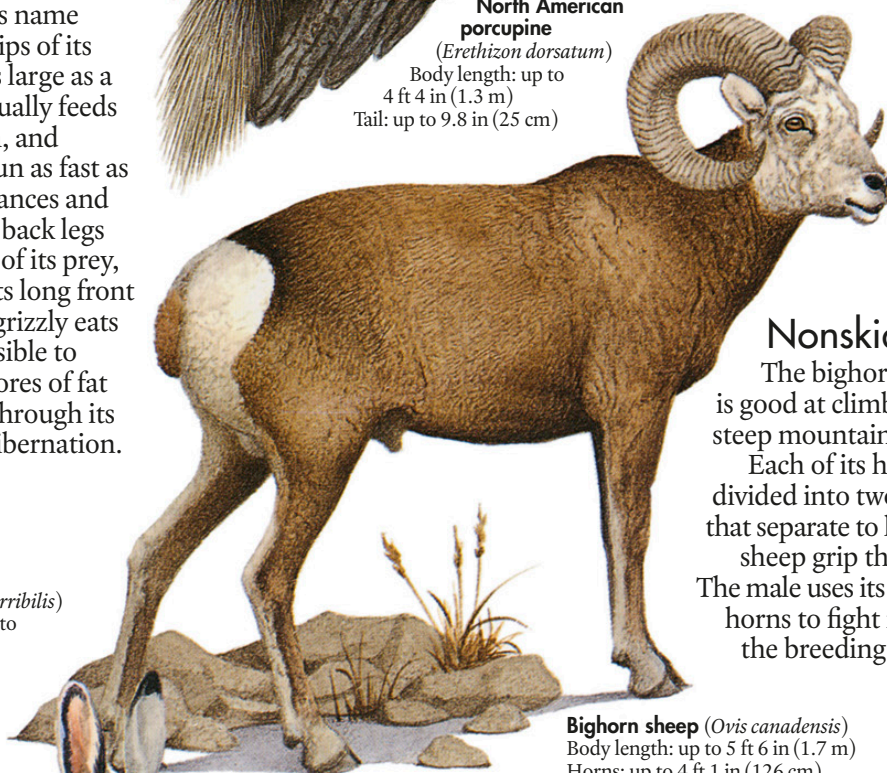
The porcupine's furry coat hides about 30,000 spiky hairs, called quills. When threatened, the porcupine turns its back, raises its quills, and lashes its tail. Its barbed tail quills stick into an enemy's skin.



North American porcupine (*Erethizon dorsatum*)
Body length: up to 4 ft 4 in (1.3 m)
Tail: up to 9.8 in (25 cm)

Nonskid feet

The bighorn sheep is good at climbing the steep mountain slopes. Each of its hooves is divided into two halves that separate to help the sheep grip the rocks. The male uses its curving horns to fight rivals in the breeding season.



Bighorn sheep (*Ovis canadensis*)
Body length: up to 5 ft 6 in (1.7 m)
Horns: up to 4 ft 1 in (126 cm)

Winter white

In summer the snowshoe hare has brown fur, but in winter it grows a white coat for camouflage against the snow. It also develops dense fur on its feet, which stop it from sinking into the snow.



Snowshoe hare (*Lepus americanus*)
Length: up to 23 in (58 cm)

Spotted camouflage

The bobcat's spotted coat helps it blend in with its environment, so that it can creep up on its prey. It usually feeds on rabbits and hares, but will eat almost any reptile, mammal, or bird. It can even kill a deer, providing enough food for a week or more.



Bobcat (*Lynx rufus*)
Height at shoulder: 22.8 in (58 cm) Length: up to 3 ft 9 in (1.2 m)